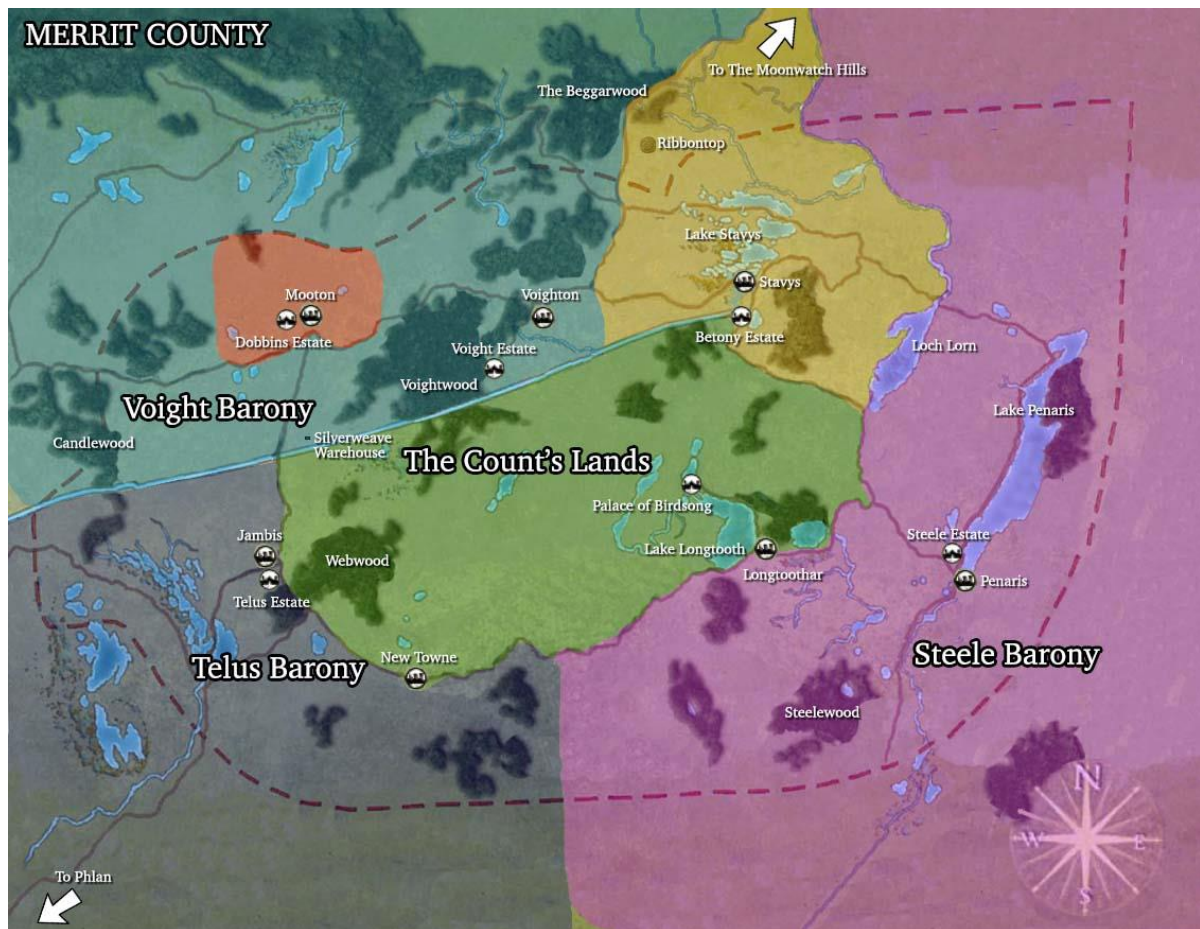


“From Death, Life.”



Lathander paints a rosy face on death, but dying is hard. Blood, pain, and terror are all that you know until you fall into oblivion.

If you are lucky, you awaken in the presence of my beloved Morning Lord. All is well again. If you are unlucky, you live through your suffering. You awaken still in the world, consumed by the horror of your circumstances. I was unlucky. I survived. The trauma of our encounter with the Hag will be with me till the end of my life.

I pushed myself up off the ground, out of the dirt and webs. I heard conversation close by, so I stood and followed the sounds. Newborn kittens had more strength. My injuries were life threatening. The Hag had been unkind and saved my life, but only by just enough that I still breathed. My armour was scraped and torn and covered in blood. The buckles were broken, and parts were missing.

I saw Harken first, then the Hag, and then the Ogre Spider. There was no sign of Etienne.

“Where's Etienne?”

The Hag's answer was the stuff of nightmares. I was struck dumb as she described Etienne's heroic self-sacrifice with evil cackling glee. I will miss our Champion keenly. In remembrance of him, I will end this Hag, her sister, and all their wicked progeny even if it takes me the rest of my days.

I watched and listened. Harken had debased himself to save my life. Disgust and shame were all over his face, at least for those who knew him well. He was negotiating with the Hag to save the Telus Barony. While negotiation was Harken's forte, the Hag wanted what she wanted, which was Harken.

Good! More of the bitch's progeny to kill. In Lathander's own words, before there is life, there is death.

I refused to be included in the Hag's machinations. I had not asked to be saved and would have gone to Lathander most willingly. Robbed of the hard-earned opportunity to gaze on the face of my beloved Morning Lord, I stood apart from Harken and the Hag while they concluded business.

My skin crawled with disgust on Harken's behalf. Although the Hag was presenting as a beautiful and desirable woman, I knew what was underneath. So did Harken. In this guise, the Hag was like an apple. Delicious on the outside but rotting away on the inside from her blackened core.

Then they both disappeared. The Hag must have been eager to consummate her deal with Harken. Bile was rising in my throat at the thought of him having to go to bed with that horror. Lathander's teachings on sexual union had nothing to do with coercion or control. The Hag had perverted a joyous and life-affirming act into just another form of selfish aggrandisement.

I was alone in the web-covered ruins of Jambis, except for giant spiders and one traitorous wretch whose days were numbered. I knew that if I saw our erstwhile guide, I would kill him outright. Best for him if he stayed hidden, or better yet, ran for his life. I presented a fearsome visage. Covered in blood. Armour destroyed. My murderous disposition driven by rage and grief was surely plain on my face. If he saw me, I hoped he would have the good sense to flee, and fast. I still had a working crossbow.

The handful of healing prayers I had left to me drew the warmth of Lathander's touch into my body. I was barely strong enough to make the journey on foot back to the Telus Estate. I set off to the south of Jambis hoping the guard captain we met earlier would lend me a horse. I was in no fit state to walk all the way back to Mooton where Harken, Etienne, and I had stabled our horses.

As I dragged one foot in front of the other towards the Telus Estate, I prayed to Lathander again. Would He recognise Etienne's heroism and ultimate sacrifice? Provide a good word on Etienne's behalf to the Source of his Champion abilities? I wanted Etienne's spirit to be hearty and hale in the celestial hall of his chosen God. He deserved that reward given the unspeakable horror of his death.

Praying with my whole heart while listening out for the thudding rush and clacking jaws of giant spiders was difficult, but possible. I had plenty of motivation. When I finished my prayer of intercession on Etienne's behalf, I scanned the terrain for crossbow targets. None came into view before I reached the Telus Estate, not even our traitorous guide.

Baron Telus' loyal captain was concerned for me and my missing companions. His compassion was heartening so I told him the sparest narrative of Etienne's death and Harken's disappearance. Even that nearly broke me.

I warned the captain that if Baron Telus contravened the rules of hospitality again, then the Baron would revert to his cursed form. If the Baron did not learn to curb his arrogance, I would ensure no further support from outside the Telus Barony. Not after we were betrayed to the Hag by the guide the captain assigned us.

The captain started speaking again. I held up my hand.

"No excuses! All I want is a horse. Far too small a recompense for Lord Betony and our Champion. A horse, and I will be gone from here."

He had the good sense to listen.

I had forgotten Telus Barony horses were preyed upon by spiders of all sizes. There was also little in the way of food and care for them. The surviving mare the captain gave me was in a worse state than I was. However, we were both eager to leave the Telus Barony behind us. The mare and I compromised on a slow canter broken by bouts of walking so we could regain breath.

In Mooton I paid the gawping stableboys two gold pieces each to take diligent care of the mare, and of Harken and Etienne's horses. The mare needed extra oats and carrots to fatten her up. I warned the boys I would be back for my other horses in a few days. If they did not look healthy and well cared for, the boys would feel the wrath of the Morning Lord on their heads.

I took my beautiful gift from Nikolai out of his stall, got the boys to saddle him, and then tried to mount him. It was only through my horse's patient efforts that I managed to climb up onto his saddle. I was exhausted and hung off the side of him while he leaned away from me to balance my weight, broken armour and all. Eventually we had it sorted. I directed him out of the stable and back onto the road out of Mooton.

To where though? Baroness Adella Voight's prior invitation came to mind. I would have to take the road east to Voighton, then southwest to the Voight Estate. A long ride, but if I had understood the conversation between Harken and the Hag correctly, and yes, I know her name now, I just refuse to say it, then I only had a bare handful of days to organise our defences.

I hoped Baroness Voight would adhere to the rules of hospitality, regardless of my state of dress. I needed a safe place in which to recover, and my home at the Betony Estate was too far away. I would never make it that far in my present condition. Critical information I had gained listening to Harken's negotiations with the Hag must be passed on to Baroness Voight, and to Nikolai, Baron Steele. I could not risk a longer journey without first alerting our allies of the Hag and her intentions.

My arrival at Baroness Voight's demesne was heralded by a rider from her nearest checkpoint. He rode out at speed ahead of me on the orders of the unit's leader. I was weaving about in the saddle by the time I reached the checkpoint and had to be helped off my horse. The checkpoint guards were generous with water, food, and bandages. Lathander, bless them all.

I continued to Baroness Voight's main household with an escort of two more riders from the checkpoint. My story of giant man-eating spiders and malicious Hags must have given them cause to request additional soldiers in person. Either that, or they were detailed to help me if I fell off my horse. To my great relief, Baroness Voight welcomed me straight into her infirmary and the tender care of her primary healer. I only consented after making sure my horse was well taken care of.

Baroness Voight's keen curiosity warred with her genuine concern for my wellbeing, winning my complete trust. I asked her most humbly to send an urgent invitation to Baron Steele to join us, as I confessed, I did not have the strength of mind to tell my story twice over again.

In the gap between sending a messenger and receiving Nikolai, Baroness Voight insisted I rest. I tried, I really did, but every time I closed my eyes, I felt the Oger Spider's fangs stabbing into me. In the end, the healer gave me something to drink that pulled me past nightmares and into ... well, I was unaware, but the potion worked wonders.

On awaking, I found myself in the company of three of Baroness Voight's personal staff intent on making me presentable. These women had me bathed, dressed in borrowed finery, hair pinned up, lips glossed, and cheeks pinkened with military precision. The great pity was they could do nothing about the haunted look in my eyes, my drawn face, and my shattered demeanor. I shooed them out, then knelt in the middle of the expansive guest room.

Lathander, help me. I cannot do this alone. Will Harken ever come back to us? If he does, will he still be as he was, or will he be a slave to the Hag? Could I still trust him if he returned? These and so many other questions filled my mind. What to do, what to do?

One of the many reasons I love Lathander is because He never disappoints. All you must do is ask Him. I looked across the room at the lovely carved wood writing desk, at the elegant paper and envelopes with Baroness Voight's crested stamped on them, at the tall quill and jeweled glass ink bottle. Thank you, my beloved Morning Lord. Thank you with all my heart.

I sat at the writing desk and set out a sheet of paper, took up the quill, and dipped it in the ink. I had just finished putting quill to paper when Baroness Voight swept through the door.

"Baron Steele has arrived."

As I followed Baroness Voight through the central hallway and into the receiving room, I saw through the main doors that Nikolai had not travelled alone. His retinue of heavily armed soldiers were dismounting in the courtyard. One was holding Nikolai's horse as Nikolai ran up the courtyard steps two at a time. I was grateful he had the good sense not to ride all the way from his estates alone. Perhaps Baroness Voight's urgent invitation relayed what the advance rider had told her yesterday.

It does a woman's ego no end of damage to see the object of her affection stare at her in horror. I took in Nikolai's shocked glance as he entered the room where Baroness Voight and I were standing.

"Lady Beatris, what in the name of all the Gods happened to you?" Nikolai shifted from foot to foot, like he wanted to do something but thought he did not have permission. Curious.

Baroness Voight motioned for us to sit in the armchairs around the fireplace. "Please."

Nikolai and I took opposite armchairs while Baroness Voight took the one between us.

I drew a deep breath, calmed my racing heart, and began at the beginning. I was uninterrupted all the way to "and so here we are."

Stunned silence. Then the questions started. I was overwhelmed even though I did my best to answer them all. I held up my hand and they both stopped talking.

"I have every reason to believe the Hag means you harm, Nikolai."

I ignored Baroness Voight's raised eyebrows at my use of Nikolai's first name only.

"Deal with the vase of flowers as you would a mortal enemy. Hide it, destroy it, or do not let it into your home. The Hag is a shape changer. Be careful of new acquaintances. Perhaps even be wary of old acquaintances."

I stood up and stepped closer to Nikolai's armchair. He stood up and met me halfway, as a gentleman should. We were barely a foot apart. Baroness Voight watched us over steepled fingers.

I held out my hand to Nikolai, the envelope between my thumb and fingers.

"I have devised a clever passphrase so that you might recognise me, the real me, as opposed to a Hag who has changed shape to look like me. I believe I can say this passphrase with far more conviction than she ever could. I invite you to provide an answering passphrase of your own choosing, Nikolai, so that I might not be similarly deceived by a shape changed Hag. Your passphrase does not have to be any reflection of mine, just whatever you are comfortable to say to me."

Nikolai took the envelope from my hand. As he pulled it open and took out the folded sheet of paper, the keenest regret I had when I lay dying passed out from my heart and dissipated into the warm air around us. I watched his face as he read what I had written on the paper.

“I love you, Nikolai Steele.”